

Case Study 1

Case 1: Performance Problems at Orion Digital Services

Orion Digital Services, a growing data-processing firm, recently reorganized its operations to meet increasing client demands. As part of the restructuring, **Mariam**, an experienced analyst, was promoted to supervise a newly formed team of six employees responsible for processing high-volume customer data within strict deadlines.

During the first six weeks, Mariam observed that team performance varied significantly despite similar job responsibilities. One employee, **Rashid**, completed tasks quickly but became visibly frustrated when errors were pointed out. He often interpreted feedback as personal criticism and occasionally reacted defensively during team meetings. Another employee, **Lina**, showed strong technical understanding but avoided presenting her work during review sessions, stating privately that she feared negative evaluation. A third employee, **Imran**, repeatedly made errors when given verbal instructions but showed marked improvement when tasks were provided in written form.

Mariam also noticed that the team's productivity declined during periods of extended overtime. Several employees reported headaches, irritability, and difficulty concentrating after long shifts. Despite these challenges, Mariam found that team morale improved noticeably after she publicly acknowledged accurate work and encouraged collaboration.

While discussing the situation with the Human Resources department, Mariam learned that Rashid had previously worked in an environment where supervisors used strict disciplinary methods for mistakes. Lina reported that she had always experienced anxiety when speaking in front of groups, even during her academic years. HR also advised Mariam that the organization was planning to implement structured feedback sessions and employee wellness programs.

Mariam realized that improving team performance required more than technical supervision. She needed to understand how psychological principles could explain individual differences in behavior, learning, motivation, and performance within the workplace.

Case Questions

Q1. Using the **nature–nurture debate**, explain how both inherited traits and environmental experiences may influence employee behavior in this case.

Q2. Apply the **behavioral perspective** to explain why public acknowledgment of accurate work improved team morale and performance.

Q3. Using the **cognitive perspective**, analyze why Imran performed better when given written instructions rather than verbal ones.

Q4. Apply the **psychoanalytic perspective** to explain Rashid's defensive reaction to feedback.

Q5. Using the **biological perspective**, explain how overtime work affected employee productivity and behavior.

Q6. Apply the **subjectivist (humanistic) perspective** to explain Lina's reluctance to present her work and suggest how Mariam can address this issue.

Q7. Using **Gestalt psychology**, explain why Mariam should consider team interactions as a whole rather than focusing only on individual employees.